DAILY READING • 样张

The Dove on the Gangway

2026-11-14 · 当天 50 词全部覆盖 · 全文 608 词 · 5 段

短文

The dove on the banner above the gangway was a white bird printed on blue canvas, moving with the wind. The exhibition had been open for three days, and the outcome of the whole week would be settled tonight, when the ambassador came aboard. Behind the reception desk a girl in a grey jacket handed me various press materials and told me not to be deceived by the calm. A strip of the forward deck had been roped off for the ribbon cutting, she said. By long usage that space belonged to the engine exhibitors, and the two sides had already had a clash over it. I had sufficient time to walk the ship, so I transmitted short notes to my editor at every turn.

Down in the forward hold, the folk from a firm called Marlow were setting up their demonstration again. Their main competitor, a Dutch company with a bigger stand, had spent the morning handing out catalogs that listed better numbers. A technician in his fifties aimed a small laser at a steel plate and, with a quick movement of his palm, caught the cut piece before it fell. It was a piece of wit I had not expected on a warship, and presently the crowd around him was three deep and still laughing. He said one thing had become shameful: every firm now sent a delegate who could talk but not repair anything. On impulse he had stopped going to the evening receptions altogether.

The controversy started quietly, with a civilian engineer asking why a decommissioned patrol ship should host a trade fair at all. A youngster from his team pointed at the gun mount left on the deck as a monument and asked whether the reform of the navy's image required keeping the guns. I stood by the rail and observed the exchange: two men, one old and one young, both polite, both unwilling to give ground. By six the ribbon for the opening ceremony was still lying in its box, and a delicate silence had settled over the reception area. For a moment the organisers seemed close to despair, because the ambassador was already in the car.

The ambassador arrived at ten past six in a dark coat, and the formal part of the evening began with a short speech about the horizon of civilian shipping. She had been briefed beforehand by her staff and chose her words carefully, since any mention of the guns would

arouse the anger of half the room. Her representation of the ship as a place where machinery could be shown without secrecy sounded honest, and even the young engineer nodded. I tried to formulate a question about the intermediate models on display, but a waiter pushed a warm soda into my hand and the moment passed. Behind her the funnel cut the sky, and beyond the rail the water was turning pink.

The crash came before the ribbon: a small camera drone, flown by a keen young photographer, hit the mast and dropped into the water beside the hull. Nobody was hurt, and the ambassador made a diplomatic joke about the dangers of flying machines, which the crowd accepted with relief. The principal reason I remember that evening, though, is not the drone but what happened to the story I had to file. My editor wanted me to cite three sources and to frame the whole event as a success, with no exception for the argument on the deck. I anticipated trouble, and it came: the young engineer resigned from his firm's stand that night, packed his gear into two boxes, and left before the cake.

解析 · 行间留白，可直接手写

The dove on the banner above the gangway was a white bird printed on blue canvas, **moving with the wind**. The exhibition had been open for three days, and the outcome of the whole week would be settled tonight, when the ambassador came aboard. Behind the reception desk a girl in a grey jacket handed me various press materials and told me not to **be deceived by** the calm. A strip of the forward deck had been **roped off** for the ribbon cutting, she said. **By long usage** that space belonged to the engine exhibitors, and the two sides had already **had a clash over** it. I had sufficient time to walk the ship, so I transmitted short notes to my editor at every turn.

> **moving with the wind** 随风摆动 move with + 名词表示随…而动，with 引出动作所依的力，不用 by；by the wind 只强调施动者，读起来生硬
>
> **be deceived by** 被…所蒙骗 deceive 用于被动多接 by；表示“自己看错情况”时用 deceive oneself about sth，不接 by
>
> **roped off** 用绳子圈起来隔开 rope off 是动补结构，off 强调隔出范围；作定语要写 a roped-off area，加连字符
>
> **By long usage** 按长期惯例 usage 表“惯例”时不可数，by long usage = 依循长久以来的做法；表“使用量”则可数，如 water usage
>
> **had a clash over** 因…发生了一次冲突 clash 作名词与 over（事由）、with（对象）连用；作“撞击声”讲时也是可数名词

Down in the forward hold, the folk from a firm called Marlow were **setting up** their demonstration again. Their main competitor, a Dutch company with a bigger stand, had spent the morning **handing out** catalogs that listed better numbers. A technician in his fifties **aimed a small laser at** a steel plate and, with a quick movement of his palm, caught the cut piece before it fell. It was **a piece of wit** I had not expected on a warship, and presently the crowd around him was three deep and still laughing. He said one thing had become shameful: every firm now sent a delegate who could talk but not repair anything. **On impulse** he had stopped going to the evening receptions altogether.

> **setting up** 搭建，布置 set up 代词作宾语要放中间（set it up）；名词化写成 setup，重音前移且不分开
> **handing out** 分发（逐份递给多人） hand out 强调一份份发出；比较 hand in（上交）、hand over（移交），三个短语的副词不可互换
> **aimed a small laser at** 把一台小激光对准 aim sth at sth 是“把…对准”；不带宾语时 aim at 表“旨在”，两种用法的 at 都不可省

> **a piece of wit** 一句妙语，一点风趣 wit 表“风趣”时不可数，靠 a piece of 计量；wits 变复数才指“智力、头脑”，如 lose one's wits
>
> **On impulse** 一时冲动之下 on impulse 是固定介词搭配，中间不加冠词；若加形容词则说 on a sudden impulse

The controversy started quietly, with a civilian engineer asking why a decommissioned patrol ship should host a trade fair at all. A youngster from his team pointed at the gun mount left on the deck as a monument and asked whether the reform of the navy's image required keeping the guns. I stood by the rail and observed the exchange: two men, one old and one young, both polite, both unwilling to **give ground**. By six the ribbon for the opening ceremony was still lying in its box, and a delicate silence had settled over the reception area. For a moment the organisers seemed **close to despair**, because the ambassador was already in the car.

> **give ground** 退让，让步 give ground 是固定短语，ground 不加冠词也不加 s；反义说法是 hold one's ground
>
> **close to despair** 几近绝望 close to 后接名词或动名词；despair 作名词不可数，不说 a despair，动词形式才表示“感到绝望”

The ambassador arrived at ten past six in a dark coat, and the formal part of the evening began with a short speech about the horizon of civilian shipping. She had been **briefed beforehand** by her staff and chose her words carefully, since any mention of the guns would **arouse the anger of** half the room. Her representation of the ship as a place where machinery could be shown without secrecy sounded honest, and even the young engineer nodded. I tried to formulate a question about the intermediate models on display, but a waiter pushed a warm soda into my hand and the moment passed. Behind her the funnel cut the sky, and beyond the rail the water was turning pink.

> **briefed beforehand** 事先被告知情况 brief 作动词表“向某人交代情况”，常用 brief sb on sth；beforehand 是一个词，作状语，不写 before hand
> **arouse the anger of** 激起…的愤怒 arouse 多接情绪类抽象名词（anger / interest / suspicion）；不及物的“发生”是 arise，别混用

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> **packed his gear into** 把装备塞进 gear 表“装备、行头”时是不可数集合名词，不加 s；表“档位”才可数，如 in first gear

译文

舷梯上方横幅上那只鸽子是我最先注意到的——一只印在蓝帆布上的白鸟，随风摆动。展会已经开了三天，而这一周的结果要到今晚才见分晓，届时大使将登船。接待台后一个穿灰夹克的姑娘递给我一叠各式媒体材料，还提醒我别被眼前的平静骗了。她说前甲板有一窄条已经用绳子圈起来，留给剪彩用。可按长期惯例，那块地方属于发动机展商，双方已经为它起过一次冲突。我有足够时间走完整条船，于是一路把短消息发给编辑。

在前舱里，一家叫 Marlow 的公司的人又在搭他们的演示台。他们的主要竞争对手——一家展位更大的荷兰公司——一上午都在发目录，上面的数字更好看。一位五十多岁的技师把一台小激光对准钢板，手掌一翻，在切下的那块落地前接住了它。这份风趣我没料到会出现在一艘军舰上，此刻围着他的人已经站了三层，还在笑。他说有一件事已经很不像话：如今每家公司派来的代表都只会说话，不会修东西。就为这股冲动，他干脆不再参加晚上的招待会。

争议是悄悄开始的——一位民用工程师问，一艘退役巡逻舰凭什么办贸易展。他团队里的小伙子指着留在甲板上当纪念碑的炮座，问海军形象改革是否非得留着炮。我靠在栏杆边看着这场交锋：一老一少两个男人，都很客气，都不肯让步。到六点，开幕要用的丝带还躺在盒子里，接待区笼罩着一层一触即破的沉默。有一刻主办方几乎绝望了，因为大使已经在车里。

大使六点十分到，穿深色大衣；晚会的正式部分以一段简短的致辞开场，谈的是民用航运的前景。她的幕僚事先通了气，因此她用词很小心，因为只要提到那些炮，就会激起半屋子人的愤怒。她把这条船描述成一个可以公开展示机械的地方，听上去很诚实，连那个年轻工程师都点了头。我想就展出的中档机型拟一个问题，可侍者把一杯温汽水塞进我手里，时机就过去了。她身后烟囱切开了天空，栏杆外的水正泛出粉色。

撞击发生在剪彩之前：一架小型摄影无人机——由一位热心的年轻摄影师操控——撞上桅杆，掉进了船体旁的水里。没人受伤，大使就飞行器的危险说了句圆滑得体的玩笑，人群松了口气。但我记住那晚的主要原因不是无人机，而是我要交的那篇稿子后来的遭遇。编辑要我引用三个消息源，还要把整件事框成一次成功，甲板上那场争执不许算作例外。我预料到会有麻烦，麻烦果然来了：那位年轻工程师当晚就从公司的展台辞了职，把设备装进两个箱子，在切蛋糕之前就走了。